



All too easy?: Errani and Vavassori, both doubles specialists, defended their title comfortably. REUTERS

combined singles rankings while eight others were given wild cards. While the changed scoring format irked the purists, the entry system enraged the players. At other Slams, the combined doubles ranking of the two players is taken into consideration for mixed doubles, but since every Major is a separate entity, the entry criteria can be changed.

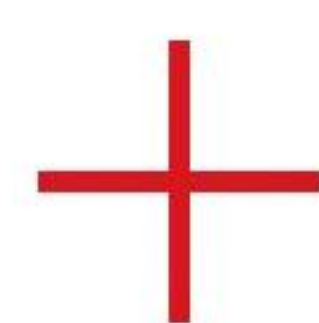
The USTA's decision effectively shut the door on most doubles specialists, for whom Grand Slams are financially a big deal. None of the Top 10 from the ATP doubles rankings made the cut, while from the WTA doubles Top 10, only No. 1 Taylor Townsend and No. 4 Errani could enter — and that

too after receiving wild cards. Letting top singles players, who already earn well, take away a major chunk of the total prize money of USD 2.36 million didn't help either.

Having more doubles specialists, rather than just Errani and Vavassori, could have made the tournament more competitive despite the changed scoring system. Out of 15 matches, nine ended in less than 50 minutes. Only two fixtures, including the final, went to a 10-point match tiebreak. The tactics, the court positioning, and the overall chemistry required for doubles — most of the teams lacked them.

After Errani and Vavassori got the job done, they were 'congratulated' by fellow doubles specialists.

"Doubles on TOP! Statement made! Forza Italia! How about allowing more doubles specialists next time to spice



The line-up

Based on singles rankings

[1] Jack Draper (GBR)/Jessica Pegula (USA)
[2] Taylor Fritz (USA)/Elena Rybakina (KAZ)
[3] Casper Ruud (NOR)/Iga Swiatek (POL)
[4] Holger Rune (DEN)/Amanda Anisimova (USA)
Daniil Medvedev/Mirra Andreeva
Frances Tiafoe (USA)/Madison Keys (USA)
Alexander Zverev (GER)/Belinda Bencic (SUI)
Andrey Rublev/Karolina Muchova (CZE)
[Alternates] Christian Harrison (USA)/Danielle Collins (USA)

Via wild cards

Carlos Alcaraz (ESP)/Emma Raducanu (GBR)
Novak Djokovic (SRB)/Olga Danilovic (SRB)
Reilly Opelka (USA)/Venus Williams (USA)
Andrea Vavassori (ITA)/Sara Errani (ITA)
Gael Monfils (FRA)/Naomi Osaka (JPN)
Ben Shelton (USA)/Taylor Townsend (USA)
Lorenzo Musetti (ITA)/Caty McNally (USA)

it up? Let's not make it too easy for Vava and Sara!" wrote Poland's Jan Zielinski, who won two mixed doubles titles in 2024, on social media platform X. Rajeev Ram, a three-time US Open mixed doubles champion, posted, "Full credit to Errani and Vavassori. I'm sure it wasn't easy to be the overwhelming favourites in this event and then get the job done."

Will the Australian Open, French Open, and Wimbledon follow the US Open route and tinker with the format of mixed doubles — a category exclusively played at the Majors, team competitions, continental events, and the Olympics? Or rather, should they?